OFFICIAL CORPORATE DOCUMENTATION

MERIDIAN TECHNOLOGIES INC.

Comprehensive Employee Handbook & Operational Governance Framework

Document ID: MTI-HBK-2026-V4 | **Classification:** Internal Confidential | **Effective:** Fiscal Year 2026–2027 | **Custodian:** Human Resources & Legal

1. Executive Welcome & Organizational Mission

Welcome to Meridian Technologies Inc. As a high-growth technology leader providing enterprise cloud architectures, workflow automation systems, and applied artificial intelligence solutions, our success depends directly upon the caliber, integrity, and shared vision of our team members. This handbook outlines the mutual commitments, legal protocols, performance standards, and cultural foundations that govern our global enterprise.

Our Core Mission

To engineer resilient, scalable software systems that liberate global businesses from repetitive operational complexity, driving ethical innovation and customer-centric value across critical sectors.

Our Vision 2030

To establish the global benchmark for enterprise workflow resilience, achieving operational excellence through transparent engineering, inclusive leadership, and zero-compromise security posture.

2. Corporate Identity & Shared Values

The Four Pillars of Meridian Culture

- **Intellectual Rigor & Ownership:** We treat complex engineering challenges with meticulous scientific validation. Every team member acts as an empowered owner of their work outcomes.
- **Radical Candor with Psychological Safety:** We communicate directly, respectfully, and without political gamesmanship. High standards coexist with genuine support and empathy.
- **Uncompromising Security & Compliance:** In a world of elevated operational risks, customer trust is our paramount asset. We adhere strictly to data privacy, audit, and governance directives.
- **Speed with Scalability:** Velocity is meaningless if software architectures crumble under production load. We balance rapid product delivery with sustainable, modular engineering.

Every employee, contractor, and executive director is expected to read, understand, and adhere to the guidelines set forth within this manual. Continued employment constitutes acceptance of these operational and governance standards.

Table of Contents & Handbook Architecture

This operational manual is organized into distinct functional domains designed to provide complete clarity over organizational policy, rights, obligations, and escalation paths across our global operations.

Section	Subject Title & Functional Focus	Page	Governance Unit
Section 01	Executive Welcome, Mission, Values & Architecture	Page 01–02	Executive Leadership
Section 02	Employment Classifications & At-Will Doctrine	Page 03	People Operations
Section 03	Recruitment, Onboarding & Introductory Probation	Page 04	Talent Acquisition
Section 04	Standard Work Hours, Overtime & Core Collaboration	Page 05	Workforce Management
Section 05	Remote Work, Hybrid Framework & Regional Policies	Page 06	Workplace Services
Section 06	Professional Code of Conduct & Workplace Decorum	Page 07	People & Culture
Section 07	Anti-Harassment, Equal Employment & Non-Discrimination	Page 08	Legal & Compliance
Section 08	Whistleblower Safeguards & Conflict Resolution	Page 09	Ethics Board
Section 09	Compensation Philosophy, Payroll & Deductions	Page 10	Finance & Payroll
Section 10	Comprehensive Health, Wellness & Insurance Coverage	Page 11	Total Rewards
Section 11	Paid Time Off (PTO), Sick Leave & Holidays	Page 12	People Operations
Section 12	Statutory Leaves, Parental Support & Bereavement	Page 13	Total Rewards
Section 13	Information Security, Device Use & Access Control	Page 14	SecOps & IT
Section 14	Data Privacy, GDPR/CCPA & Regulatory Compliance	Page 15	Legal Affairs
Section 15	Intellectual Property, Inventions & Trade Secrets	Page 16	Legal Affairs
Section 16	Travel, Business Expenses & Procurement Standards	Page 17	Corporate Finance
Section 17	Performance Reviews, OKRs & Promotions	Page 18	People & Strategy
Section 18	Corrective Action & Separation Procedures	Page 19	Human Resources
Section 19	Legal Disclaimers & Employee Acknowledgement	Page 20	General Counsel

Document Authority & Scope of Application

This handbook applies to all regular full-time, part-time, temporary, and contracted personnel employed by Meridian Technologies Inc. and its wholly-owned subsidiaries. In the event of a conflict between general guidelines in this document and regional jurisdictional statutes, local labor laws take precedence.

3. Employment Classifications & The At-Will Doctrine

Meridian Technologies Inc. designates employment classifications to establish clear eligibility parameters for salary structures, benefit packages, statutory deductions, overtime considerations, and career advancement paths. Every employee is formally informed of their category upon issuance of their written Offer of Employment.

Primary Workforce Classifications

Classification Category	Definition & Scheduled Hours	Benefit Eligibility	FLSA Status
Regular Full-Time (RFT)	Scheduled to work 40 hours per standard calendar week on an ongoing, indefinite basis.	Full medical, retirement matching, annual bonuses, equity vesting, full PTO.	Exempt / Non-Exempt (Role-Dependent)
Regular Part-Time (RPT)	Scheduled to work between 20 and 31 hours per calendar week on a sustained basis.	Prorated PTO; statutory medical contributions as defined by regional threshold.	Non-Exempt
Temporary / Fixed-Term	Engaged for specific project scopes or finite durations not exceeding twelve (12) consecutive months.	Statutory benefits only; ineligible for equity grants or company bonus programs.	Non-Exempt
Independent Contractors	Vendors and consultants operating under executed Statements of Work (SOW) via third-party contracts.	Ineligible for corporate benefits; responsible for independent tax withholding.	Contractor (1099 / B2B)

At-Will Employment Doctrine (Jurisdiction-Specific)

For all employees based in the United States, employment with Meridian Technologies Inc. is strictly "at-will." This means that either the employee or Meridian may terminate the employment relationship at any time, for any lawful reason or no reason, with or without prior notice or cause. No manager, team lead, or company representative possesses the authority to enter into verbal agreements altering the at-will status.

> **Important Legal Clarification on Representations**
> Nothing in this employee handbook, internal communications, company intranet portals, or verbal discussions during performance reviews creates an express or implied contract of permanent or guaranteed employment. Only the Chief Executive Officer and Head of Legal may execute written contracts modifying at-will terms.

4. Recruitment, Onboarding & Introductory Probation

Meridian Technologies is dedicated to identifying, attracting, and retaining world-class talent through merit-based, non-discriminatory recruitment practices. Our hiring pipeline includes technical evaluations, structured behavioral interviews, background verifications, and professional reference reviews.

The 90-Day Introductory Evaluation Period

Every newly appointed regular full-time and part-time employee participates in an intensive 90-calendar-day introductory period commencing on their first official working day. This framework enables both the company and the employee to assess role compatibility, technical performance, and alignment with organizational values.

Milestone Stage	Core Objectives & Deliverables	Evaluation Metrics
Days 1 – 15: Immersion	Hardware provisioning, identity federation setup, compliance training modules, buddy assignment.	100% completion of Mandatory Security & Harassment training.
Days 16 – 45: Integration	Codebase familiarization, first pull request/documentation delivery, department cross-shadowing.	Initial 30-day check-in with direct People Manager.
Days 46 – 90: Execution	Independent ownership of assigned tasks, team sprint contributions, stakeholder collaboration.	Formal 90-Day Performance & Cultural Alignment Review.

> **Probationary Period Policies & Outcomes**
> Completion of the 90-day introductory period does not guarantee continued employment for any fixed duration, nor does it alter the underlying at-will nature of the working arrangement. In instances where performance or cultural adherence fails to meet established benchmarks, Meridian reserves the discretion to extend the probationary period by up to 30 additional days or initiate formal separation.

Verification & Pre-Employment Clearances

Offers are contingent upon successful verification of academic credentials, past employment history, criminal background checks (in compliance with regional Fair Chance acts), and right-to-work documentation (e.g., Form I-9, right-to-work visas). Falsification or intentional omission of material facts constitutes grounds for immediate revocation of offer or termination.

5. Work Hours, Overtime & Core Collaboration

To foster seamless international operations while respecting personal autonomy, Meridian operates under an intentional hybrid scheduling model combining flexible working windows with mandatory core synchronization hours across all operating engineering and support units.

Standard Operating Shifts & Core Windows

Geographic Cluster	Standard Business Window	Mandatory Core Collaboration Hours
Americas (AMER)	08:00 – 18:00 EST / PST	10:00 – 15:00 EST (Sync meetings, demos, architectural reviews)
Europe, Middle East, Africa (EMEA)	08:30 – 17:30 GMT / CET	10:00 – 15:00 CET (Team standups and inter-region alignment)
Asia-Pacific (APAC)	09:00 – 18:00 SGT / IST	11:00 – 16:00 IST (Sprint handoffs and global releases)

Overtime Regulations (Non-Exempt Employees)

Employees classified as Non-Exempt under the Fair Labor Standards Act (FLSA) or regional employment laws are eligible for overtime compensation. All overtime work must be pre-approved in writing by the direct People Manager prior to commencement.

- **Standard Overtime:** Hours worked in excess of 40 active working hours in a standard workweek are compensated at 1.5 times the employee's regular hourly rate.
- **Mandatory Time Tracking:** Non-exempt personnel must accurately log all active working, rest, and meal periods via the corporate HRIS timekeeping platform. Off-the-clock work is strictly prohibited.
- **Meal and Rest Breaks:** Employees are provided a minimum 30-minute unpaid meal break for shifts exceeding five continuous hours, alongside two paid 15-minute rest breaks.

> **Strict Prohibition of Unauthorized Overtime**
> Working unauthorized overtime or failing to accurately document working hours violates company policy and may lead to disciplinary measures up to and including termination, while accrued overtime will be compensated in accordance with legal requirements.

6. Remote Work & Hybrid Operational Framework

Meridian Technologies supports a flexible work model that blends remote work with access to regional innovation centers. The policy is designed to empower employees while preserving accountability, data privacy, and cross-functional team alignment.

Work Arrangement Categorization

- **Office-Centric (On-Site):** Roles requiring physical hardware laboratories, on-premises data center administration, or administrative facility presence (minimum 4 days on-site).
- **Hybrid Flexible:** Standard corporate baseline allowing employees to split time between regional hubs (2 days/week) and certified home offices (3 days/week).
- **Fully Remote:** Designated personnel operating outside a 50-mile radius of any Meridian physical office, working 100% from an approved home location.

Home Office Ergonomics & Equipment Allowances

To support productive remote working environments, regular full-time hybrid and remote personnel are provided standard enterprise hardware and financial setup stipends upon hiring.

Category	Allowance / Frequency	Eligible Expenses
Hardware Kit	Provided upon onboarding	MacBook Pro / ThinkPad, docking station, dual 27" monitors, enterprise headset.
Ergonomic Setup	$750 (One-Time Reimbursement)	Ergonomic desk chair, motorized standing desk, monitor arms, anti-fatigue mats.
High-Speed Internet	$60 / Month (Taxable)	Direct broadband subsidy to guarantee minimum 50 Mbps down / 15 Mbps up.

> **Remote Security & Compliance Guardrails**
> Employees operating remotely must conduct all business activities on company-managed devices with active endpoint protection. Operating from public venues (cafes, airport lounges) requires mandatory VPN routing and physical privacy screen shields to safeguard proprietary company and client data.

7. Professional Code of Conduct & Workplace Decorum

At Meridian Technologies, our reputation as a trusted technological partner is established through individual and collective integrity. We demand professional behavior, transparent communication, and mutual respect in all business interactions, whether in person or across digital channels.

Foundational Conduct Standards

Digital Communication Etiquette
All internal discussions across Slack, email, Zoom, and code review threads must maintain professional decorum. Tone should remain constructive, evidence-based, and courteous at all times.

Conflict of Interest
Employees must disclose external advisory positions, board seats, secondary commercial activities, or investments in competitors to People Ops and Legal via the annual Disclosure Portal.

Gifts & Commercial Hospitality
Employees may not accept gifts, meals, or entertainment from vendors or clients exceeding $100 in cumulative annual value without written authorization from the Chief Compliance Officer.

Substance-Free Environment
Possession, consumption, or impairment by alcohol, illicit narcotics, or non-prescribed controlled substances during working hours or at corporate facilities is strictly forbidden.

Public Communications & Media Inquiries

Individual employees may not speak on behalf of Meridian Technologies to journalists, press outlets, financial analysts, or podcast hosts without explicit written clearance from the Corporate Communications unit. Social media posts must include explicit disclaimers: *"The opinions expressed here are my own and do not necessarily represent the views of Meridian Technologies Inc."*

> **Zero Tolerance for Retaliation and Unethical Conduct**
> Meridian strictly prohibits fraudulent accounting, misrepresentation of software capabilities, bribery (Foreign Corrupt Practices Act compliance), and unauthorized public disclosures. Violations lead to immediate termination of employment and possible civil or criminal liability.

8. Anti-Harassment, Equal Employment & Non-Discrimination

Meridian Technologies Inc. provides an inclusive, equitable, and harassment-free working environment. We do not tolerate discrimination or harassment of any employee, contractor, candidate, or visitor on the basis of protected characteristics under federal, state, or municipal law.

Protected Status Classifications

Protected classifications include race, color, religious creed, ancestry, national origin, sex, gender, gender identity, gender expression, sexual orientation, genetic information, marital status, medical condition, disability, age (40 and older), military or veteran status, or any other characteristic protected by applicable law.

Prohibited Behavior	Illustrative Examples	Direct Impact & Liability
Verbal Harassment	Epithets, derogatory comments, offensive jokes, disparaging remarks regarding cultural identity.	Creates hostile work environments; subject to immediate investigation and separation.
Sexual Harassment (Quid Pro Quo)	Conditioning promotions, compensation increases, or favorable assignments upon romantic or sexual favors.	Strict liability for supervisors; immediate termination and reporting to authorities.
Hostile Environment Harassment	Unwanted physical contact, displaying explicit imagery, persistent unwelcome romantic solicitations.	Pervasive interference with performance; zero tolerance under company policy.

Reasonable Accommodations Framework

Meridian provides reasonable accommodations to qualified individuals with physical or mental disabilities, as well as for sincerely held religious beliefs and practices, unless doing so imposes an undue hardship on company operations. Employees seeking accommodations should initiate an interactive dialogue with People Operations.

9. Whistleblower Safeguards & Grievance Protocols

Transparency and accountability require safe avenues for raising ethical concerns. Meridian has established multi-tiered reporting mechanisms to ensure improper conduct, safety hazards, financial fraud, or harassment are addressed without fear of reprisal.

Formal Reporting Hierarchy & Escalation Paths

Escalation Level	Responsible Contact	Operational Focus
Tier 1: Direct Resolution	Immediate People Manager / Team Lead	Day-to-day workflow friction, resource constraints, minor interpersonal disputes.
Tier 2: People Partner	Assigned HR Business Partner (HRBP)	Policy interpretations, formal workplace grievances, performance dispute reviews.
Tier 3: Executive Legal	VP of People / General Counsel	Severe harassment, discrimination claims, contractual disputes, executive conduct.
Tier 4: Anonymous Hotline	Independent EthicsPoint Third-Party Portal	Financial misconduct, insider trading, severe regulatory breaches, fraud (24/7/365).

Investigation Protocol & Confidentiality

Upon receipt of a complaint, the Legal and People Operations teams initiate an impartial, timely investigation. Investigations include separate interviews with the reporting party, witnesses, and the accused individual, along with documentary analysis of communications and logs. All inquiries remain confidential to the fullest extent possible.

> **Comprehensive Whistleblower Protection Guarantee**
> Meridian strictly prohibits retaliation against any individual who in good faith reports harassment, discrimination, regulatory non-compliance, or financial fraud, or who participates in an official investigation. Any employee engaging in retaliatory behavior will face immediate termination of employment.

10. Compensation Philosophy, Payroll & Deductions

Meridian's compensation philosophy is built to reward performance, maintain market competitiveness across tech hubs, and provide clear advancement opportunities. Total compensation incorporates base salary, performance incentives, and long-term equity participation.

Payroll Schedule & Payment Distribution

Salaries and hourly wages are distributed on a bi-weekly cycle, concluding every second Friday for a total of 26 pay periods per calendar year. Payments are processed via electronic direct deposit into up to three employee-designated banking accounts.

Component	Description & Application	Frequency / Administration
Base Salary	Fixed cash compensation calibrated against regional tech benchmarks (P75 market percentile).	Bi-weekly direct deposit; reviewed annually during Q1 cycle.
Annual Performance Bonus	Incentive payout tied to both individual OKR attainment and aggregate corporate ARR targets.	Calculated post-fiscal audit; disbursed in March annually.
Equity Incentive Grants (RSUs)	Restricted Stock Units vesting over four years with a standard one-year initial cliff (25/75 model).	Administered via Morgan Stanley Shareworks platform.
Mandatory Deductions	Statutory federal, state, and local income tax withholding, Social Security (FICA), Medicare.	Itemized on bi-weekly electronic pay stubs via ADP Portal.

> **Salary Confidentiality Rights**
> Under the National Labor Relations Act (NLRA) and relevant state statutes, employees retain the legal right to discuss their compensation, benefits, and working conditions with peers. Meridian does not restrict employees from openly discussing wages.

11. Comprehensive Health, Wellness & Benefits

Meridian Technologies provides a benefits program supporting the physical health, mental well-being, and long-term financial security of employees and their eligible dependents. Benefits take effect on the first calendar day of the month following the employment start date.

Core Benefit Offerings

Plan Type	Provider & Coverage Summary	Corporate Premium Subsidy
Medical Insurance	Cigna / Blue Cross Blue Shield (Choice of PPO, HDHP with HSA, or HMO).	90% employee premium covered; 75% for eligible dependents.
Dental & Vision	Delta Dental Premier / VSP Vision (Preventive 100%, basic restorative 80%).	100% employee coverage; 80% dependent coverage.
401(k) Retirement Plan	Fidelity Investments (Pre-tax traditional and Roth 401k election options).	100% employer match up to first 4% of total base salary.
Life & Disability	Group Term Life (2× base salary) + Short-Term and Long-Term Disability coverage.	100% company-paid benefit for full-time employees.

Employee Assistance Program (EAP) & Mental Health

To support mental well-being, Meridian partners with Modern Health to provide all employees and their households with up to twelve (12) complimentary, confidential mental health therapy sessions per calendar year, accessible through digital telehealth or licensed local practitioners.

> **Annual Open Enrollment Guidelines**
> Changes to health elections, flexible spending accounts (FSA), and dependent status may only occur during the November Open Enrollment window, unless a qualifying life event takes place (e.g., marriage, birth, adoption, or loss of alternative coverage) within 30 days of the occurrence.

12. Paid Time Off (PTO), Sick Leave & Paid Holidays

Rest and rejuvenation are essential to sustaining high-performance engineering and sustainable careers. Meridian provides a generous paid time off structure alongside dedicated sick leave and recognized corporate holidays.

PTO Accrual Schedules (Regular Full-Time)

Tenure Tier	Annual PTO Accrual	Accrual Rate Per Pay Period	Maximum Accrual Cap
Years 0 – 2	18 Days (144 Hours)	5.54 Hours / Bi-Weekly Pay Period	216 Hours (1.5× annual)
Years 3 – 5	23 Days (184 Hours)	7.08 Hours / Bi-Weekly Pay Period	276 Hours (1.5× annual)
Years 6+	28 Days (224 Hours)	8.62 Hours / Bi-Weekly Pay Period	336 Hours (1.5× annual)

Sick Leave Policies & Health Management

Employees receive ten (10) standalone paid sick leave days per calendar year, available on January 1. Sick leave may be utilized for personal physical or mental illness, medical appointments, or caring for an immediate family member. Medical documentation may be requested for consecutive absences exceeding three business days.

Observed Corporate Holidays

Meridian officially observes eleven (11) paid holidays annually: New Year's Day, Martin Luther King Jr. Day, Presidents' Day, Memorial Day, Juneteenth, Independence Day, Labor Day, Thanksgiving Day, Day after Thanksgiving, Christmas Eve, and Christmas Day. In addition, employees receive two (2) floating holidays annually for cultural or religious observance.

> **PTO Cap Enforcement**
> Once an employee reaches their maximum accrual cap, PTO accruals pause until hours are used. Meridian does not allow pay-in-lieu-of-PTO during active employment; team members are encouraged to utilize their earned leave.

13. Statutory Leaves, Parental Care & Bereavement

Meridian Technologies supports team members through major life events, medical emergencies, and family obligations through statutory compliance and enhanced corporate leave provisions.

Comprehensive Parental Leave Framework

We believe parents need dedicated bonding time. Meridian offers sixteen (16) weeks of 100% fully paid parental leave to all regular full-time employees following the birth, adoption, or foster placement of a child. This benefit applies equally to all eligible parents, regardless of gender.

Leave Type	Paid Duration	Job Protection	Eligibility Threshold
Paid Parental Leave	16 Weeks (Fully Paid)	Guaranteed role/salary parity upon return	Full-time after 6 months continuous service
Family & Medical Leave (FMLA)	Up to 12 Weeks (Unpaid/Coordinated)	Statutory federal reinstatement protection	12 months tenure + 1,250 hours worked
Compassionate Bereavement	5 Days (Immediate Family) / 3 Days (Extended)	Fully paid leave	Immediately eligible upon first day of work
Jury Duty & Civic Service	Up to 10 Days (Fully Paid)	Protected civic leave	Immediately eligible; court summons required

Military Leave (USERRA)

Employees entering active military duty, national guard reserve activations, or specialized training are granted unpaid leaves of absence in strict accordance with the Uniformed Services Employment and Reemployment Rights Act (USERRA), retaining seniority, health benefits eligibility, and reinstatement privileges.

> **Coordination with State and Federal Programs**
> Meridian coordinates paid leave benefits with state-sponsored programs (e.g., California PFL, New York PFL, Washington PFML) to ensure employees receive full salary continuation during authorized leaves, without reduction to their base earnings.

14. Information Security, Device Management & Access

As an enterprise infrastructure provider, Meridian maintains rigorous information security protocols. Protecting infrastructure, intellectual property, and client data is a non-negotiable operational baseline for every staff member.

Mandatory Device & Access Protocols

Security Domain	Mandatory Policy Requirement	Enforcement Vector
Endpoint Encryption	Full-disk FileVault (macOS) / BitLocker (Windows) with 256-bit AES encryption.	Enforced via Jamf Pro / Microsoft Intune MDM.
Identity Verification	FIDO2 hardware security keys (YubiKey) or Okta Verify MFA required.	Conditional access policies on all corporate SSO apps.
Password Complexity	Minimum 16 characters, managed via enterprise 1Password; no reuse permitted.	Automated 90-day password strength audits.
Software Installation	Only approved applications from the Managed Self-Service catalog may be run.	Endpoint privilege management; no local root/admin access.

Acceptable Use & Network Monitoring

Corporate laptops, mobile devices, servers, and internal collaboration platforms are company property. Meridian reserves the legal right to monitor, inspect, audit, and log network traffic, file transfers, and system access to safeguard company assets, prevent data exfiltration, and ensure regulatory compliance.

> **Strict Prohibition of Shadow IT and External Storage**
> Employees may not connect unapproved USB drives, external storage devices, or unauthorized cloud storage solutions (e.g., personal Google Drive, Dropbox) to company hardware. Violations may result in security reviews and disciplinary action.

15. Data Privacy & Regulatory Compliance (GDPR / CCPA)

Meridian Technologies operates globally, processing significant volumes of enterprise data. We strictly comply with international data privacy laws, including the General Data Protection Regulation (GDPR), California Consumer Privacy Act (CCPA/CPRA), and SOC 2 Type II controls.

Data Classification & Handling Framework

Data Classification	Definition & Examples	Handling & Storage Mandate
Public (L1)	Marketing collateral, published blog posts, public product documentation.	No restriction on external sharing or public storage.
Internal (L2)	Internal roadmaps, sprint notes, corporate directories, non-sensitive memos.	Restricted to authenticated employees; no public indexing.
Confidential (L3)	Source code, non-public financials, product roadmaps, contract terms.	Role-based access controls (RBAC); encrypted in transit/at rest.
Restricted / PII (L4)	SSNs, banking records, passwords, client end-user personally identifiable data.	Highest isolation tier; tokenization, logging, DPO authorization required.

Data Subject Access Requests (DSAR) & Breach Notification

Employees receiving requests from external individuals seeking to exercise data privacy rights (e.g., right to access, right to be forgotten) must forward inquiries to the Data Protection Officer (`dpo@meridian.tech`) within 24 hours. In the event of an identified security breach, Meridian operates under a strict 72-hour regulatory notification SLA.

> **Annual Privacy & Compliance Recertification**
> All employees are required to complete the annual Data Protection and SOC 2 Awareness module. Failure to complete recertification within 30 days of notification may result in suspension of system access credentials.

16. Intellectual Property, Inventions & Trade Secrets

Meridian's core value rests upon proprietary software, patented algorithms, trade secrets, and institutional knowledge. As a condition of employment, all personnel execute the Proprietary Information and Inventions Agreement (PIIA).

Intellectual Property Assignment Scope

Company-Owned Inventions
All inventions, source code, designs, algorithms, architectures, patents, and technical documentation developed during working hours, using company equipment, or relating to current or anticipated company business belong exclusively to Meridian.

Prior Inventions Exclusion
Employees retain rights over pre-existing inventions explicitly documented on Exhibit A of their signed PIIA agreement prior to starting work, provided such inventions do not utilize company assets or compete directly with active products.

Open Source Contributions
Contributing to open-source software using company hardware or referencing company projects requires advance written clearance from the Open Source Review Board (OSRB) to protect our codebases from inadvertent license contamination.

Trade Secret Protection
Proprietary customer lists, pricing matrices, pipeline code, and strategic roadmaps constitute protected trade secrets. Nondisclosure obligations survive the termination of employment indefinitely.

Defend Trade Secrets Act (DTSA) Notice

Under the Federal Defend Trade Secrets Act of 2016, individuals may not be held criminally or civilly liable under any federal or state trade secret law for disclosing a trade secret in confidence to a government official or attorney solely for reporting or investigating a suspected legal violation.

> **Post-Employment Return of Company Property**
> Upon separation of employment, all files, repositories, documentation, and digital assets must be immediately surrendered. Retaining corporate source code or client databases on personal devices post-separation constitutes actionable intellectual property theft.

17. Travel, Business Expenses & Procurement Standards

Employees traveling on behalf of Meridian or incurring business expenses are expected to exercise sound fiscal judgment. Business expenditures must be reasonable, necessary, and aligned with company goals.

Travel Expense Limits & Reimbursement Guardrails

Category	Policy Parameters	Booking / Documentation Rules
Air Travel	Economy / Coach class standard for flights under 6 hours; Premium Economy for 6+ hours.	Must be booked via Navan corporate travel portal minimum 14 days in advance.
Lodging	Standard corporate hotel room up to $250/night (Tier 1 cities: $325/night max).	Itemized folio must be submitted showing $0 balance.
Meals & Incidental	Daily per-diem cap of $85 ($110 for high-cost metros: NYC, SF, London, Tokyo).	Receipts required for all individual expenses exceeding $25.
Ground Transit	Standard ride-share (UberX, Lyft), public transit, or shared airport shuttles.	Luxury vehicle classifications (Black car, SUV) are not reimbursable.

Expense Submission & Approval Cycles

All expense reports must be submitted through the Expensify portal within thirty (30) calendar days of incurring the expense. Late submissions past sixty (60) days may be denied reimbursement and treated as personal costs.

> **Strict Prohibition of Personal Expenses**
> Corporate credit cards must be used exclusively for authorized business purchases. Using corporate cards for personal expenditures, even with intent to reimburse the company, is prohibited and may result in the revocation of card privileges.

18. Performance Reviews, OKRs & Career Growth

Meridian is dedicated to employee growth, transparent performance evaluations, and rewarding high impact. Our performance management framework combines continuous feedback with semi-annual review milestones.

The Semi-Annual Review Cycle

Evaluation Phase	Timeline	Key Actions & Artifacts
Q1 Evaluation	January – February	Annual review, base salary adjustments, bonus distributions, new equity grants.
Mid-Year Sync	July – August	Calibrations, developmental feedback, mid-year promotions, OKR recalibrations.
Continuous 1-on-1s	Weekly / Bi-Weekly	Manager alignment, blocker mitigation, career growth planning.

Objectives and Key Results (OKRs) Framework

Every department and team member establishes quarterly OKRs aligned with broader company objectives. Key Results must be measurable, ambitious, and time-bound. Performance ratings range across a five-point scale:

- **5 - Exceptional Impact:** Consistently outperforms across all metrics and elevates peers.
- **4 - Exceeds Expectations:** Delivers high quality work beyond core role expectations.
- **3 - Fully Meets Expectations:** Consistently achieves high standards and team objectives.
- **2 - Needs Improvement:** Inconsistent output; requires targeted intervention.
- **1 - Unsatisfactory:** Does not meet core job requirements; subject to a formal Performance Improvement Plan.

> **Internal Mobility & Career Ladders**
> Employees in good standing who have completed a minimum of twelve (12) months in their current role are eligible to apply for internal transfers or lateral promotions across global departments via the internal career portal.

19. Corrective Action & Separation Procedures

Meridian believes in open communication and providing opportunities to address performance shortfalls. However, continued failure to meet expectations or serious policy violations will result in progressive disciplinary action or separation.

Progressive Disciplinary Action Matrix

Disciplinary Stage	Application Trigger	Formal Process & Duration
Stage 1: Documented Counseling	Initial minor performance gaps, repeated attendance issues, minor policy infractions.	1-on-1 discussion documented in HRIS; 30-day monitoring window.
Stage 2: Written Warning	Failure to correct Stage 1 issues or significant operational errors.	Formal letter outlining specific deficiencies and required metrics; signed by employee.
Stage 3: Performance Improvement Plan (PIP)	Sustained underperformance affecting critical business deliverables.	Rigorous 30 or 60-day plan with weekly milestones; binary pass/fail criteria.
Stage 4: Separation	Failed PIP completion or serious misconduct.	Termination of employment relationship in coordination with Legal.

Gross Misconduct & Immediate Termination

Certain actions bypass progressive discipline and result in immediate termination of employment for cause. Gross misconduct includes theft, intentional damage to company property, physical violence, unlawful harassment, falsification of records, unauthorized disclosure of trade secrets, or intentional cybersecurity violations.

> **Offboarding Logistics & Final Paycheck Compliance**
> Departing employees must return all company laptops, security badges, access keys, and proprietary documentation on their final working day. Final compensation, including earned base pay and accrued unused PTO, will be disbursed in accordance with regional statutory deadlines.

20. Legal Disclaimers & Employee Acknowledgement

This handbook summarizes corporate policies, operating practices, and benefits across Meridian Technologies Inc. It replaces and supersedes all previous oral statements, regional manuals, and written guidelines distributed prior to the effective date.

> **Management Rights & Policy Modifications**
> Meridian Technologies Inc. reserves the right to modify, revoke, suspend, or amend any policy, benefit, or practice described within this manual at its discretion, with or without prior notice. Any such revisions will be formally communicated via official corporate distribution channels.

Employee Receipt & Formal Acknowledgement

Please review the following statements carefully, sign in the space provided below, and submit this executed document to People Operations via the DocuSign portal within ten (10) business days of your commencement date:

- I acknowledge that I have received, read, and understand the Meridian Technologies Inc. Employee Handbook.
- I understand and agree that my employment is at-will (unless otherwise governed by regional statutory contracts), and that either I or the company may terminate employment at any time, with or without cause or notice.
- I agree to comply with all company policies, including the Code of Conduct, Anti-Harassment, Information Security, Intellectual Property, and Travel & Expense guidelines.
- I understand that this handbook does not constitute an express or implied contract of employment.

Employee Full Name (Printed)	Employee ID Number
Employee Signature	Date (MM/DD/YYYY)